get what my wife and I used to call ‘templed out’ – that is to say, exhausted by these temple cities. The immensity of their ambition and the sheer abundance of artistic endeavour and detail that has gone into each one over the course of centuries tend to overwhelm; all of them being dominated by one or more gigantic entrance gates in the form of pyramidal *gopuram*s built not just to represent a multiplicity of gods and attendants climbing up to the heavens but also, and very deliberately, to overawe. One can easily come away defeated, so newcomers would do well to be selective, whatever the guide or guidebooks might say – or risk suffering the tourist's version of post-traumatic stress.

But Nageshwaram matters, because this is where Chola patronage on the grand scale kicked off, in the last decade of the ninth century or the early years of the tenth century, with much of that patronage coming from the Chola queens.

This is made clear in the majestic array of stone statuary that line the Nageshwaram temple walls, and its long, dark corridors, each figure set in niches and just short of life-size. The local guides may tell you that these represent various gods and goddesses. Some of them do, but some are also portraits in stone of various members of the royal house, along with their spiritual teachers and the occasional minister or two, all donors to the temple.

There is something quite magical about these figures, with their languorous, impossibly elongated limbs, wasp waists and hourglass figures, and their serene gaze, that sets them apart from everything that has gone before. They can only have been the work of one or more master-carvers in stone, perhaps a school of sculptors led by some local unsung Michelangelo or Praxiteles. One of the most beguiling of these statues is said to represent Lord Rama’s wife Sita, but without any supporting evidence. A less orthodox view is that she is a portrait in stone of a remarkable Chola queen: Sembiyan Mahadevi.